

novose, or SQ for short—essential for good gut bacteria to thrive

WHOLE GRAINS, BEANS AND LEGUMES

Contain essential fibre for microbiome to grow and survive

ALMONDS, WALNUTS, PISTACHIOS

Have polyphenols and antioxidants, which can help beneficial gut bacteria multiply. Do not eat their skin, though, as it may impair digestion

YOGHURT, PICKLE, KOMBUCHA, SOURDOUGH BREAD

The live cultures and yeasts within them can aid digestion

LEEKS, BANANA, RYE, OATS, WHEAT BRAN, GARLIC AND ONION

These prebiotics contain Fructans, a type of fermentable carbohydrate that feeds good gut bacteria just like fibre



"People ignore prebiotics like onion, garlic and turmeric, and focus on yoghurt or fermented vegetables—but prebiotics are equally important. Dehydration, too, is bad for gut health"

—DR V. KRISHNA DEEPIKA
Dietitian, Apollo Hospital, Hyderabad

How to Improve Your Gut Health

While people who suffered from bad digestion once turned to Eno, *chooran* or the luridly pink Digene syrup, today there is a greater understanding of gut health and a larger range of effective solutions. But first you need to know exactly what your problem is. Common symptoms of an unhealthy gut include bad breath, nausea, constipation, diarrhoea or pain when passing stool. In fact, the nature of one's faeces is a bellwether of gut health. Doctors recommend the Bristol Stool Chart—which describes shapes and types of stools—as a guide for observable signs of an ailing gut. A few tests can determine if you have dysbiosis or bacterial imbalance in the gut. The hydrogen breath test, for example, requires one to drink a sugar solution and breathe into a special balloon, which is then tested for gases produced by bacteria.

There are enough new medicines to treat dysbiosis, even as doctors simultaneously warn that antibiotics overuse can kill good bacteria along with the bad. There is also a proliferation of alternative remedies, from simple ones to fancy trends. "These include Korean microbiome walking (frequent walking) or practices like slow eating," says Dr Meel. People have also switched to gluten-free diets, herbal teas, kefirs, kombuchas and kimchi. However, doctors recommend a sustainable overall lifestyle change in the long run. This can be done by taking pro- and prebiotic supplements, fermented foods and fibre and even meditation. "Probiotics (e.g. Lactobacillus and Bifidobacterium), prebiotics (dietary fibre and alpha-lactalbumin), fruits and vegetables could have protective effects against mental disorders by enhancing beneficial gut microbiota and suppressing harmful ones," says Dr Singla. "No one ingredient can improve gut health. Include colourful fruit and vegetables rich in antioxidants and minerals, as nutrient deficiency wipes out microbiota," says Dr V. Krishna Deepika, a dietitian at Apollo Hospital, Hyderabad. "People ignore prebiotics like onion, garlic and turmeric, and focus on yoghurt or fermented vegetables—but prebiotics are equally important. Dehydration, too, is bad for gut health."

In severe cases such as IBS, doctors may even recommend a faecal microbiota transplant (FMT), a medical procedure that transfers healthy bacteria from a donor's stool into a patient's gut. In India, an AIIMS-led study found a population in Haryana to have the healthiest gut in the country. Their bacteria could be used as donor stool. The healthy stool is collected, mixed with saline water, filtered and then transferred into a patient's colon through a colonoscope, enema, nasogastric tube, or freeze-dried and administered in capsule form. FMT is what Sangeeta Karmakar resorted to after all else, including Ayurveda, failed. "I had three sessions this year from July to September and have been without medication for the past one month. I can feel a huge change in my body," she says. In 2023, the US Food and Drug Administration (FDA) also approved Vowst, the first faecal microbiota over-the-counter drug fit to be taken orally.

It is also useful to begin at the beginning. While not much is known about how we inherit gut microbiota, breastfeeding is considered to play a vital role. Dr Ghoshal rues the increasing use of infant milk substitutes. "They are not the same as natural breastfeeding," he says. Breast milk contains beneficial bacteria that help develop an infant's gut microbiota. He also expresses concern that we live in highly sanitised environments. "If you sterilise everything, how will bacteria develop?" he asks. Too much of a good thing can also be bad for your health. ■